

CLIMBERS AND WALL SHRUBS

One of the most versatile of plant groups, climbers bring height to the garden, adding interest to walls and fences, and covering structures such as arches and pergolas with flowers and foliage. A number of shrubs can also be trained against walls and fences to create textures, patterns, and backdrops to beds and borders.

What are climbers and wall shrubs?

Most climbers are woody, evergreen, or deciduous plants, while a few are herbaceous perennials, or summer-flowering annuals. Climbers can be self-clinging or twining (with or without tendrils), or scandent—scrambling species that do not cling. It is important to identify the climbing method of your plant, since this dictates the method of support it needs. Self-clingers such as Virginia creeper (*Parthenocissus quinquefolia*) climb up their supports using adhesive pads, while ivies (*Hedera*) and the Swiss cheese plant (*Monstera deliciosa*) use aerial roots to attach themselves to vertical surfaces. Self-clinging climbers may initially need to be guided to their support with canes (see box below) but will then become self-supporting. By contrast, twiners coil

around the slim stems of a host plant or they will need wires, mesh, or a trellis to cling to if they are wall-trained. Clematis, passion flowers (*Passiflora*), hop (*Humulus lupulus*), sweet peas (*Lathyrus*), and morning glory (*Ipomoea*) fall into this group.

Scrambling plants like winter jasmine (*Jasminum nudiflorum*) attach themselves loosely by threading their flexible stems through host plants or over a framework of their old stems made in previous seasons. On smooth surfaces, such as walls and fences, their stems must be tied into wires or a trellis attached to the support, as they have no other means of clinging.

Wall shrubs such as chaenomeles, pyracanthas, and ceanothus are not natural climbers, but can be trained to decorate walls or fences. Some are best grown in this way, as they require the additional shelter and support a wall provides.

Ornamental features

Climbing plants have a range of attractive foliage forms, from the lobed leaves of *Tropaeolum speciosum* and palmate foliage of *x Fatshedera lizei*, to the heart-shaped leaves of *Actinidia deliciosa*. Leaf surfaces also offer textural contrasts, from the downy *Vitis vinifera* to glossy ivies (*Hedera*).

PLANTING A CLIMBER

Before planting, attach eye screws and horizontal wires, or a trellis, to the wall or fence. The lowest wire should be about 20in (50cm) above soil level, and the others 12–18in (30–45cm) apart. Work plenty of organic matter into the soil.



ABOVE *Wisteria*-clad wall

Climbers, such as *Wisteria sinensis*, need a sturdy trellis or wall for support to display their heavy flowers to perfection. When grown around a window, the subtle scent of its flowers can be appreciated indoors and out.



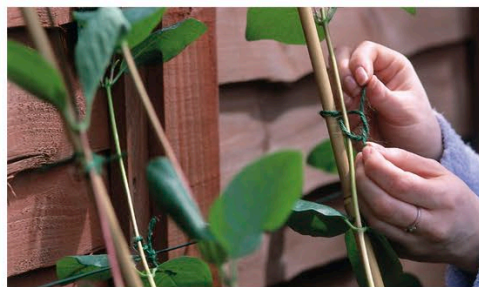
1 Dig a planting hole

Water the climber before planting. Dig a hole twice the diameter and deeper than the root ball, 18in (45cm) from the fence. Dig a slightly deeper hole for clematis, since they need to be planted 4in (10cm) deeper than the top of their root ball.



2 Plant the climber

Arrange a fan of canes in the hole. Place the climber in the hole and slant toward the canes. Backfill with some soil enriched with rotted organic matter. Untie the stems from their original support and spread them out ready to attach to the canes.



3 Tie in the stems

Using soft garden twine, tie the stems to the canes using a figure eight. Train the lower stems on to the lower wires and any tall stems at the center of the plant to cover the high wires.



4 Firm in the soil

Firm in the climber and create a shallow saucer shape around the base of the plant so that moisture runs into the area above the roots. Water, and apply a bark mulch, keeping it clear of the plant stems.